

So you're thinking about teaching

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI. Classroom teaching came out at 3.6 out of 10 — one of the lower scores we found.

Entry-level software development scored 8.1.

And here's the part almost nobody expects: AI is genuinely good news for classroom teachers. It's taking the marking, the planning and the paperwork — which is the exact list people give when they explain why they left.

The 60-second version

- Classroom teaching is well protected. Online teaching scores nearly double.
 - AI takes the evening and weekend work, not the actual teaching.
 - **The interesting bit:** teaching is more automatable than nursing or medicine — and still scores low.
 - The real risks are pay, workload and behaviour. None of them are new, and none are about AI.
 - Where you teach matters more than whether you teach.
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The thing worth understanding

This one's genuinely interesting, and it teaches you something about every career, not just this one.

We rate teaching 7.7 out of 10 on "how much can AI already do." That's higher than nursing. Higher than medicine. Higher than most jobs we scored.

Lesson planning, resource creation, differentiating work for different abilities, marking, feedback, reports — nearly all of it is automatable now.

So why does teaching still score 3.6?

Because the other five factors run the other way, hard.

- You have to physically be there — a room of thirty is a management problem before it's a teaching one
- Parents hand over their children. Nobody delegates that to software.

- You need certification, and supervising minors is legally reserved
- Every class is a different mix of people on a different day

The lesson: what protects a job isn't the absence of automatable tasks. It's the presence of everything else.

And here's the proof

SETTING	SCORE
Special education	3.1
Elementary / early years	3.6
Secondary STEM	3.8
Secondary general	4.1
Online teaching / tutoring	6.8

Same subject knowledge. Same automatable tasks. Take away the room, the physical presence and the certification requirement, and that 7.7 automatability rating suddenly dominates.

Nothing about the work changed. The setting did.

What AI is actually taking

The evening and weekend work.

Planning. Marking. Differentiating three versions of a worksheet. Report writing. Chasing admin.

That list is the reason people give when they leave teaching. So automating it is one of the more straightforwardly good developments in this entire index — most careers don't get that deal.

What it can't touch: holding a room of thirty. Noticing the kid who's gone quiet this week. Knowing why this student is stuck rather than that one. Being the adult a child trusts.

The skill nobody's teaching yet

Two, actually.

Knowing when the AI is wrong. Generated feedback that misreads a kid's work is worse than no feedback. You can only catch that if you know the children well enough.

And working out what assessment even means now. Every student in your future classroom will have these tools. If a generated essay can pass your assignment, the assignment was measuring the wrong thing. That's the biggest unsolved problem in schools right now, and the profession badly needs people who can think about it rather than just ban things.

Your opening: AI is already in almost every classroom, and it's arriving faster than the training. Under half of teachers report getting any guidance on it. So you'd arrive knowing something most experienced colleagues are working out alone.

What we won't soften

The risks in teaching are real, and none of them are robots.

Pay. It lags comparable graduate careers, especially mid-career. This is the most-cited reason people leave and it's worth looking at actual numbers where you live — year one, year five, year fifteen.

Behaviour. Harder than most people expect, and the thing training prepares you for least well.

Workload — though this is the bit AI genuinely helps with.

And where you teach matters enormously. Turnover runs at 19.1% in high-poverty schools against 12.9% in low-poverty ones. That's a bigger gap than between some entirely separate careers.

One genuinely good piece of news: RAND has been tracking district-reported turnover for five years, and it's been declining toward pre-pandemic levels. That's the opposite of what most coverage suggests.

Does this actually sound like you?

The honest question first: are you drawn to children, or to your subject?

Loads of people go into teaching because they love history or maths. That's a good start and it isn't the job. The job is thirty young people in a room, all day, most of whom are less interested in your subject than you are.

Teaching suits people who:

- **Can hold a room** — the single most important trait, and the hardest to fake
- **Get energy from people** rather than being drained by them
- **Are patient with slow progress** and can explain the same thing eight ways
- **Are organised**, because the admin is real even after automation

Harder if you need quiet to function, find conflict draining, or want control over your own time — the school day is fixed and it starts early.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **How many weeks in actual classrooms, starting when?** The best predictor of whether people stay.
- **How is behaviour management taught?** If it's one module, that's an answer.
- **Do they teach you to use AI tools and rethink assessment?**
- **What proportion of their graduates are still teaching at three years? At five?**

And choose your subject deliberately. Maths, physics, chemistry, special education and bilingual teaching are in real shortage — which means better employability, better pay and far more choice about where you live.

Two things worth doing

Get into a classroom before you commit. Volunteering, assisting, helping at a summer scheme — anything. Nothing else answers the "is this me" question as fast, and the thing that surprises people is almost never the teaching. It's the noise, the pace and the behaviour.

Then find a teacher three to five years in — not someone about to retire — and ask what a normal week actually looks like. Hour by hour.

One more thing

Special education scores best in this whole profile at **3.1**, and has the deepest shortages of any teaching route.

It's demanding work and it isn't for everyone. But it's chronically under-chosen, and it's worth knowing it exists as a deliberate choice rather than something people fall into.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **What's it like to be a teacher in America today?** — Pew Research, teachers in their own words on workload, pay and whether they'd recommend it. Not a recruitment brochure.
 - **Teacher turnover in the United States** — where the high-poverty versus low-poverty turnover gap comes from. The single most decision-relevant fact in this profile.
 - **Educator turnover continues declining** — RAND's five-year tracking showing the situation improving, which almost no coverage mentions.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a training provider, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.